

tify and close skill gaps ahead of time.

He notes that people strategy becomes a true business driver when CHROs actively shape leadership behaviour, culture, and capability building.

BEYOND LAG INDICATORS

Traditional HR metrics, like engagement scores and attrition, offer only a backward-looking view of organisational health.

“Many companies are still looking at what has happened, not what might happen next; it’s like driving while only looking in the rearview mirror,” says Suri.

“It starts with getting a much clearer view of skills not just what we have today, but whether those skills align with where the business is heading and where gaps are beginning to emerge,” he explains.

Organisational fluidity becomes a critical indicator. “Are people moving into new roles as needs change, or are they stuck? The ability to redeploy talent quickly is a big part of resilience,” he notes.

70 | What matters is whether people are applying new skills in their day-to-day work, Suri opines. “That’s where CHROs create real impact by helping organisations move early, with clarity, instead of reacting when it’s already too late.”

THE CULTURAL SHIFT

Ghose highlights how shifting workforce expectations are redefining the CHRO mandate. “Today’s workforce is highly transactional. People are not thinking about lifetime careers. If you tell someone what they will be 15 years from now, they are not interested. They want to know what’s on the table today,” he says.

He adds that this shift places a new responsibility on HR leaders to prepare organisations internally. “CHROs need to prepare line managers to work with the next generation of employees. There is often reluctance among leaders, and HR must bridge that cultural gap.”

Ghose points out that traditional HR priorities are no longer differentiators. “Diversity and engagement initiatives have become baseline. The expectation now is to deliver impact and scale. Young HR leaders are beginning to think beyond traditional frameworks,

WHAT’S WORKING, WHAT’S NOT

92%

of CHROs bring multi-industry experience

66%

have worked across 3+ industries

ONLY 20%

have non-HR experience

<20%

have international exposure

40%

Are from top HR institutes

SOURCE SPENCER STUART STUDY

which is encouraging.”

He leaves CHROs with a clear mandate for the future: “You must continuously re-engineer yourself. If you don’t reinvent, you risk becoming irrelevant. Staying relevant requires constant evolution both at an individual and organisational level.”

HOLDING THE LINE ON TRUST

When organisations hit tough periods, the instinct is often to pull back, control the message, or say less. In those moments, the CHRO’s role is about holding the line on trust and creating a sense of stability when everything else feels uncertain, notes Suri.

“My experience has taught me that people can handle tough times if they feel respected and informed. They understand that businesses go through cycles. So, the role of the CHRO in those moments is really about holding the line on trust. That means being open, even when the message is difficult. It means giving people clarity on what’s happening and what it means for them.”

However, he cautions that communication alone is not enough. “It’s also about action and creating an environment where people feel informed, respected, and supported, even in uncertainty.”

RETHINKING HR EDUCATION

As the CHRO role evolves, HR education is struggling to keep pace.

Curriculum design, Sripada argues, needs to evolve in real time integrating cutting-edge research with real-world experiences to build true people-centricity in an age shaped by AI and automation.

Importantly, he emphasises that the shift is not just about adding new competencies such as data or technology skills,

but about fostering deeper mindsets and worldviews.

“Business schools must prioritise stakeholder-centric thinking beyond shareholders, social responsibility, particularly the responsible use of automation and the ability to balance the triple bottom line of planet, people, and profits.”

It’s those who reinvent themselves that soar! **BT**